

Chapter 17-2

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Xu Qingzhu, who had walked out of the hospital room, hurried toward the elevator. This was the busiest time at the hospital.

The elevator entrance was crowded with people, and she stood among the crowd, trying her best to conceal herself.

The composure she had just forced made her face flush with heat. Her face and ears were bright red, her palms had broken out in a layer of sweat, making her phone damp and hot in her grip.

There were five fingernail marks in her palm where she had dug her nails in forcefully, and her nail beds showed an abnormal whiteness.

An auntie beside her asked with concern: "Young lady, are you alright? Do you need me to call a doctor for you?"

"No need, thank you, auntie." Xu Qingzhu politely declined.

She placed her hand over her heart, forcefully trying to calm her wildly beating heart.

She wasn't an actress after all—her acting skills were too clumsy.

If the lights had been on, Liang Shi would definitely have noticed her abnormality.

Fortunately, with the lights off, she could force herself to put on an act.

The elevator rose to the tenth floor. When Xu Qingzhu returned to her hospital room, a young nurse was hanging an IV drip. Hearing footsteps, she turned around and greeted her with a smile: "You're back."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu sat on the bed and took several deep breaths before she somewhat recovered.

"Lie down," the young nurse said. "The sooner you finish the IV, the sooner you can sleep."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu placed her phone on the bedside table and asked while the young nurse was inserting the needle: "Where is Dr. Zhao?"

"Making rounds," the young nurse replied. "There's a patient who needs an examination. It'll probably be a while before she's done."

"I see."

"Do you need her for something?" the young nurse asked.

"Mm, I'll call her later. Thank you," Xu Qingzhu said.

After the young nurse finished setting up the IV and left, the hospital room became quiet, and Xu Qingzhu finally completely relaxed.

A clear tear fell.

She raised the back of her hand to wipe it away.

Her phone vibrated soon after.

She reluctantly picked it up—it was a message from her mother.

【My precious Bamboo¹.】

Before Xu Qingzhu could reply, messages quickly flooded the screen.

【Your father said if it's not possible, then forget it. Don't let these things cause friction between you and Ah Shi.】

【Your father and I discussed it. Minghui² was destined for this fate. We've tried our best—there's nothing we can do about it.】

【None of this has anything to do with you. Today mommy was too emotional, so I put pressure on you.】

【I'm sorry, mommy apologizes to you. As long as you're well, that's enough. You don't need to worry about family matters. Your father and I have been through everything—this small matter won't defeat us.】

【Mommy only has you and your sister now. I'm really sorry—we shouldn't have transferred this pressure to you.】

【My precious Bamboo, mommy loves you.】

As Xu Qingzhu read these messages, her eyes reddened.

She wiped away the tears that fell again and tapped the screen to reply: 【I asked Liang Shi. The Liang family can't provide us with assistance.】

This time her mother sent a voice message: "It's okay, the Liang family has already helped us enough. Haven't you rested yet? Has your sister been giving you any trouble?"

Xu Qingzhu replied: 【Yaya has been quite well-behaved.】

She chatted with her mother for a while longer. Her mother desperately apologized to her and tried to comfort her emotions.

She also said that Minghui³ hadn't reached a dead end yet, and that her father could handle it.

Minghui Jewelry was a family business passed down from her great-grandfather, but her father really wasn't cut out for business.

The family business had begun to decline within just a few years of being passed to him.

Even though they had just received thirty million yuan in financing a few months ago, they still couldn't escape the fate of bankruptcy.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment and sent a message to her father: 【I plan to join the company.】

Footnotes:

¹ Bamboo (竹子): This is an affectionate nickname based on Xu Qingzhu's name, where "zhu" means bamboo. Chinese parents often use elements from their children's names as nicknames.

² Minghui (明輝): This refers to Minghui Jewelry, the Xu family's company name.

³ Minghui: Referring again to the family jewelry business that has been struggling financially.